Kai Gao

Contact Information

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(608) 556-8974
Department of Economics, University of Wisconsin–Madison

Education

University of Wisconsin–Madison, Ph.D. in Economics — 2027 (expected)
Fields: Industrial Organization, Environmental Economics
Committee: Panle Barwick, Jean-François Houde, Karam Kang

University of Wisconsin–Madison, M.S. in Economics — 2021

London School of Economics and Political Science, MSc in Econometrics and Mathematical Economics — 2018

University of Minnesota, Twin Cities, B.A. in Mathematics — 2017

Working Papers

Beyond the Label: Do Ecodesign Regulations Reduce Real-World Energy Use? **[Job Market Paper]**

I study the 2021 European washing-machine energy-label reform. Firms improve Eco efficiency while energy use rises in other wash programs. An equilibrium model of product design, purchases, and program choice quantifies the implications for actual electricity use and welfare.

Does Carbon Pricing Misallocate Clean Technology? Evidence from Global Shipping

I study whether geographically fragmented carbon pricing reallocates cleaner ships across routes. I use global vessel movements and emissions data around the extension of the EU Emissions Trading System to maritime transport to examine how carriers adjust vessel deployment.

Other Writing

What Drives the Repowering of Wind Turbines? Evidence from the Danish Wind Energy Industry

Work in Progress

Instrument Choice in Merger Simulations
with Adam Dearing, Lorenzo Magnolfi, and Christopher Sullivan

Work Experience

Research Assistant to Lorenzo Magnolfi — 2020–2022

Fellowships and Awards

UW–Madison Data Funding — 2026
Robock Scholarship in Empirical or Experimental Economics — 2025
Julian Granger Outstanding TA Scholarship — 2023
Harold Hardy Scholarship in Economics, University of Minnesota — 2016

Conferences and Seminars

- Industrial Organization Workshop, University of Wisconsin–Madison 2026
- Industrial Organization Lunch, University of Wisconsin–Madison 2026
- International Industrial Organization Conference (IIOC) 2025
- Alumni Conference, University of Wisconsin–Madison 2025

Teaching Experience

Instructor, Econ 460: Economic Forecasting, University of Wisconsin–Madison — Fall 2025

Teaching Assistant, Econ 310: Statistics: Measurement in Economics, University of Wisconsin–Madison — Spring, Fall 2026

Teaching Assistant, Ph.D. Math Camp, University of Wisconsin–Madison — Summer 2022